

KEYS CHANGED HER SERVE FROM A PLATFORM STANCE TO A STEP-UP ONE, ENABLING HER TO ATTACK BETTER



Dream come true: The talented Madison Keys always dreamed of emulating the superstar sisters, Venus and Serena Williams. In her 46th Major appearance at the Australian Open this year, she won her first Grand Slam crown, beating defending champion Aryna Sabalenka, 6-3, 2-6, 7-5. GETTY IMAGES

KEYS DETHRONES SABALENKA TO WIN FIRST GRAND SLAM TITLE

When four-year-old Madison Keys first saw Venus Williams on TV, she was smitten with her dress. Her sports-loving parents told her she would have to play tennis to wear it. From then on, the talented American dreamed of emulating superstar sisters Venus and Serena.

In 2009, Keys became the seventh-youngest player to win a WTA main draw match at 14 years and 48 days, and the youngest since prodigy Martina Hingis in 1994. Soon after, she beat Serena in a World TeamTennis set, prompting Serena to describe her as “a future No. 1.” In 2016, Keys became the first American to debut in the Top 10 since Serena had done so in 1999.

Ever closer to fulfilling her girlhood dream, she faced close friend Sloane Stephens in the biggest match of their lives for the coveted title at the 2017 US Open. The pressure paralysed Keys. Making 17 errors in the first seven games, she self-destructed in a 6-3, 6-0 tearful debacle.

Fast forward to this Australian Open. “I’ve obviously thought of that match endlessly for the past eight years,” said Keys with a bittersweet laugh, after upsetting world No. 2 Iga Switek in a riveting 5-7, 6-1, 7-6 (8) semifinal. Keys said she learned important lessons from that traumatic loss and a 0-6, 7-6 (1), 7-6 (5) heartbreaker to Aryna Sabalenka after leading 6-0, 5-3 in the 2023 US Open semis. “I’m probably going to be uncomfortable 99 per cent of the time that I’m on the court, and that’s OK, and I can still also play tennis through that.”

Some critics predicted Keys would never fully control her explosive but erratic game or her often-fragile nerves. Others, like Chris Evert and Lindsay Davenport, believed it was just a matter of when, not if, she’d win a Grand Slam title. Keys trained at all-time great Evert’s tennis academy in Florida from 2005 to 2011, and former No. 1 Davenport coached her in 2015 and 2017.

Bjorn Fratangelo dated Keys for seven years and became her